

Day 1 — Drafting Technical PRDs from Customer Requirements

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: take your triad's top Week-2 feature concept and start the PRD you'll ship Friday — context, problem, goals, scope, and a solution sketch crisp enough for an engineer to imagine the shape.

Where we are in the week

Week 3 is the mini-capstone. Triads carry their Week-2 strategy package and pick **one feature concept** to PRD this week. By Friday, that PRD ships, peer-reviewed.

Today produces sections 1–5 of the PRD. AC come Day 2. NFRs come Day 3. The integrated assembly happens Day 4. Reviews happen Day 5.

The non-AI rule (reminder)

This week is the discipline of producing a defensible written artifact without a generative tool. AI is off until Week 4. What's allowed: spell-check, dictionary, transcripts, your Week-1 and Week-2 artifacts.

The PRD template (today's reference; printed and on the wall)

```
# PRD — <Feature name>
**Author triad:** <names> | **Date:** <date> | **Status:** Draft

## 1. Context
## 2. Problem
## 3. Goals & non-goals
## 4. Scope (in / out)
## 5. Solution sketch
## 6. Acceptance Criteria [Day 2]
## 7. Non-Functional Requirements [Day 3]
## 8. Metrics & validation [Day 4]
## 9. Risks & open questions [Day 4]
## 10. Dependencies [Day 4]
## 11. Out-of-scope follow-ups [Day 4]
```

Activity 1 — Pick the One Feature

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Force the triad to commit to **one** feature concept from Week 2 and articulate why that one. Many triads will want to keep all three — the discipline of choosing is the work.

Setup

Each triad needs their three Week-2 feature cards, the four-dimension scoring sheet, and a blank memo template. No AI tools.

Triad protocol

1. **Re-read the 3 feature cards aloud** (5 min)
2. **Score each on 4 dimensions** (10 min). 1–5 each:
 - **Friction severity** — how big is the pain it addresses?
 - **Metric movability** — how confident are we it'll move the metric in 30 days?
 - **Build feasibility** — how achievable in one quarter?
 - **Learning value** — what do we learn even if it doesn't ship?
3. **Pick one** (10 min). Highest total score is the default; if scores tie, the triad must argue.
4. **Write the "Why this one" memo** (10 min). Two paragraphs:
 - Paragraph 1: Why this feature, in user terms
 - Paragraph 2: Why this feature, in business / strategy terms

Output

A single feature locked in, with a "Why this one" memo. The memo seeds Section 1 (Context).

Activity 2 — Section 1 (Context) and Section 2 (Problem)

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

Write the two sections that give the engineer who reads the PRD enough to **care** about the work before they read what to build.

Setup

Each triad needs Week-1 interview notes and the Week-2 journey map within arm's reach. Print or pin the PRD template. No AI.

Section 1: Context (½ page max)

What this section answers:

- Why this work? (Customer signal — pull from Week-1 interviews/tickets)
- Why now? (Strategic fit — pull from Week-2 NS / Tier Sheet)
- What changed? (If anything triggered the urgency)

What this section avoids:

- ❌ "Customers are asking for it" (vague)
- ❌ Marketing language ("delight users")
- ❌ Restating the company strategy from scratch

Section 2: Problem (½ to ¾ page)

What this section answers:

- The user's **job-to-be-done** (verb-based, in their language)
- The **friction they hit today** (specific, observed)
- Why **today's workarounds are inadequate**

Tie explicitly to the **Week-2 journey map**. Reference the friction stars.

Triad protocol

1. **Each member drafts Section 1 alone** (10 min). Three drafts.
2. **Pick the strongest** (10 min). Combine if needed.
3. **Each member drafts Section 2 alone** (10 min).
4. **Pick the strongest, combine, edit** (10 min).

What "good" looks like

- Section 1 fits on half a page.
- Section 2 quotes a real customer (from Week-1 interviews) at least once.
- The reader leaves Section 2 knowing whose Wednesday afternoon will improve.

Deliverable

Drafted Section 1 (Context) and Section 2 (Problem) appended to the triad's PRD, with at least one verbatim customer quote in Section 2.

Activity 3 — Section 3 (Goals & Non-goals) and Section 4 (Scope)

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

Define what success means **in user terms** and bound what will and won't ship in this iteration. Non-goals and out-of-scope items are the most under-valued sections of any PRD.

Setup

Each triad needs their Week-2 Tier Sheet (for metric ties) and the Sections 1–2 they just drafted. Whiteboard or worksheet for the scope table.

Section 3: Goals & non-goals

Goals (3–5 max):

- Each goal is a **user outcome**, not a feature
- Each goal is **observable** within 30 days of ship
- ❌ "Ship the dashboard" → ✅ "Dispatchers see open work without hunting"

Non-goals (2–4):

- What you explicitly will *not* do
- Often the most valuable section — pre-empts scope creep
- ❌ Skip this section → ✅ "We will not redesign the navigation bar"

Section 4: Scope (in / out)

A two-column table:

In scope	Out of scope (this iteration)
Mobile flow	Tablet layout
Online + offline draft	Offline-first sync
English only	Spanish localization

Out-of-scope is the **negotiation tool** — it tells stakeholders "I see what you might also want; here's why this iteration doesn't include it."

Triad protocol

1. **Draft 5 candidate goals** (10 min). Cull to 3.
2. **Draft 3 candidate non-goals** (10 min). Cull to 2.

3. **Draft scope table** (15 min). Force the right column.
4. **Sanity check** (5 min). Does each goal tie to a friction star or metric?

Deliverable

Section 3 (Goals & non-goals) and Section 4 (Scope in/out table) appended to the PRD, each goal tied to a Tier Sheet metric.

Activity 4 — Section 5 (Solution Sketch)

Format: Triad • 45 min + Wrap • Block 4

Purpose

Describe the solution **just enough** for an engineer to imagine its shape — not so much that you've designed it for them. This is the most-mis-written section in real-world PRDs.

Setup

Each triad needs blank paper for sketches, the Sections 1–4 they just drafted, and the Section 5 inclusion/exclusion checklist. No AI.

What goes in Section 5

- The **user-visible flow**: 4–8 steps from the user's perspective
- The **key surfaces** affected (which screens, which surfaces)
- The **hard interactions** with other systems (other products, APIs, third parties — name them)
- A **happy path** narrative (one paragraph; what a successful run looks like)
- Optional: 1–2 simple sketches or wireframes (allowed; encouraged for clarity)

What does NOT go in Section 5

- Database schema decisions
- Specific API contracts
- Class names, framework choices, library picks
- Pixel-level layout

The "engineer's first three questions" test

After writing Section 5, ask: what are the **first three questions** an engineer would ask after reading this? If those questions are about implementation choice, you've over-specified. If they're about user behavior or scope, you've under-specified.

Triad protocol

1. **Sketch the flow** (15 min). On paper. 4–8 steps.
2. **Write the happy-path paragraph** (10 min).
3. **List the hard interactions** (10 min).
4. **The three-questions test** (10 min). Each member proposes 3 engineer questions; flag any that signal over- or under-specification.

Deliverable

Section 5 (Solution sketch) appended to the PRD: flow steps, hard-interactions list, happy-path paragraph, and the triad's three-questions diagnosis.

Wrap (last 15 min)

Each triad shares with the room:

- The feature name
- One sentence of context
- One sentence of problem
- The top goal
- The top non-goal

This **two-minute share** is intentional. It catches generic feature concepts before the triad invests another 3 days drafting.

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad leaves the day with a draft PRD containing:

- ✓ Title + author + date + status
- ✓ Section 1 (Context)
- ✓ Section 2 (Problem)
- ✓ Section 3 (Goals & non-goals)
- ✓ Section 4 (Scope in / out)
- ✓ Section 5 (Solution sketch)
- ✓ "Why this one" memo (informal — feeds Section 1 if useful)